

The San Diego SMB Owner's AI-Automation Audit Checklist

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Use this before any vendor conversation. If you can't answer a question, that's a signal — not a failure.

How to Use This Checklist

Work through each section. For every "yes," write one sentence: *what happens today, and who does it*. That sentence becomes the brief for an automation that might replace 2–10 hours of weekly work.

Be concrete. "Scheduling is a pain" is not useful. "My front desk spends 3 hours every Monday morning rescheduling the week because of no-shows called in over the weekend" is useful.

At the end, count your yes answers in each section. The section with the most yeses is where to start.

Section 1 — Missed and Delayed Contacts

Every contact that doesn't hear back within a few hours either calls a competitor or forgets they needed you.

- ☐ Do you miss phone calls during peak hours, evenings, or weekends?
- ☐ Does it take more than 30 minutes to respond to a new inquiry by text or email?
- ☐ Do you lose track of leads who contacted you but didn't book or buy immediately?
- ☐ Do you manually follow up on quotes or estimates you've sent out?
- ☐ Do you have a no-show or cancellation rate above 10%?

If you checked 2 or more: A missed-call text-back, automated follow-up sequence, or appointment reminder workflow directly addresses this. The fix is usually \$30–60/month in API costs after a one-time build.

Section 2 — Scheduling and Booking

Manual scheduling is one of the highest-leverage targets for automation because the volume is predictable and the cost of errors (double-bookings, no-shows, manual rescheduling) compounds daily.

- ☐ Does someone on your team spend more than 3 hours per week managing your calendar or booking appointments?
- ☐ Do customers book through you by phone or email rather than self-serve online?
- ☐ Do you manually send appointment reminders?
- ☐ Do you handle waitlists by hand?
- ☐ Do you take reservations or table holds by phone and write them down?

If you checked 2 or more: Online self-booking with automated confirmation and reminder sequences is well-proven technology. It reduces no-shows, frees phone time, and works overnight.

Section 3 — Invoicing and Payments

Late payments and manual invoice creation are the two most common cash-flow killers in small-business operations — and both are directly automatable.

- ☐ Do you create invoices manually (in QuickBooks, Word, Excel, or by hand)?
- ☐ Do you follow up on unpaid invoices manually?
- ☐ Do you have more than 5% of invoices overdue at any given time?
- ☐ Do you manually transfer job or project data from one system (CRM, scheduling tool) into your accounting software?
- ☐ Do you send payment receipts or thank-you messages manually?

If you checked 2 or more: Invoice generation on job completion, automated payment reminders, and QuickBooks/Xero sync are all standard workflow automation. The ROI here is typically 1–3 months on a full build.

Section 4 — Customer Communication and Reviews

Consistent customer communication — confirmations, updates, follow-ups, review requests — is rarely done well manually because volume makes it hard to stay on top of every interaction.

- ☐ Do you manually send order status updates, job status updates, or project updates to customers?
- ☐ Do you ask customers for reviews? If so, do you do it manually?
- ☐ Do you have a Google review rating below 4.5 stars that you haven't had bandwidth to address?
- ☐ Do customers ever call or text asking "where's my order" or "what's the status"?

- ☐ Does your team spend time answering the same 5–10 customer questions repeatedly?

If you checked 2 or more: Automated post-job review requests, status update triggers, and FAQ-handling via SMS or chat can be built without replacing any human relationship — they handle the transactional layer so your team focuses on the relational one.

Section 5 — Internal Admin and Data Entry

If any member of your team is manually copying information from one system into another — anything that could be described as "I open X, look up Y, and type it into Z" — that's automation work.

- ☐ Does anyone on your team copy data between systems (e.g., from a booking app into a spreadsheet, or from a form into a CRM)?
- ☐ Do you track job status, project status, or client status in a spreadsheet that requires manual updates?
- ☐ Do you generate any reports by hand (weekly summaries, daily tallies, end-of-month numbers)?
- ☐ Do you manually onboard new clients — sending welcome emails, creating folders, setting up access?
- ☐ Do you maintain a contacts list or customer database that requires manual upkeep?

If you checked 2 or more: These tasks are the clearest automation wins. They require no customer interaction, the input/output is well-defined, and they recur on a fixed schedule. This is where most businesses find their first 5 recovered hours per week.

Section 6 — Staffing Costs and Offshore Work

This section is for business owners who currently pay staff — in-office or offshore — primarily for administrative, communications, or data work.

- ☐ Do you currently have a virtual assistant or offshore staff member whose primary work is administrative or data tasks?
- ☐ Does that role cost more than \$800/month?
- ☐ Have you turned down growth because you didn't want to add headcount?
- ☐ Do you have high staff turnover in an administrative role?
- ☐ Would you describe any current staff role as "they mostly handle [repetitive task]"?

If you checked 2 or more: The offshore-VA-replacement analysis is worth doing. Not every VA role is replaceable — human judgment, relationships, and creativity are not automation targets. But the portion

of the role that is repetitive, rule-based, and high-volume often is. A realistic audit will tell you which is which.

Your Score

Count the checked boxes in each section:

Section	Checked
1 — Missed Contacts	/5
2 — Scheduling	/5
3 — Invoicing	/5
4 — Customer Communication	/5
5 — Internal Admin	/5
6 — Staffing / Offshore	/5
Total	/30

0–5: You're likely running a lean operation. There may still be wins, but they'll be smaller.

6–12: There are real opportunities here. Start with the section with the most checks.

13–20: Multiple workflows are worth building. An audit will help you sequence them by ROI, not by what feels urgent.

21+: You're carrying significant manual overhead. The audit conversation will be detailed — bring your numbers.

What to Do With This

Option A — Do it yourself. Take your highest-scoring section and research the specific tools: n8n, Make, Zapier, Twilio, and your existing software's native automation features. Most of these sections have free-tier tools you can test.

Option B — Get a second opinion. The Baxter Solutions Operations Audit (\$1,500) is a 90-minute discovery call plus a written report. You'll get a prioritized list of automation opportunities, rough ROI estimates for each, and a named-stack recommendation (what to build with, in what order). No obligation to build anything. If the math doesn't work for your business, we'll tell you.

To book the audit: **baxter.solutions/audit** or email **ethan@baxter.solutions**

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